ACTIVATION

WITHOUT A BULL MARKET

Driving user activation on trading and investing platforms in volatile markets: a strategy for ONL Trade, the digital platform of Trade Private Limited

OUR ANSWER: SHOW SALARY CUSTOMERS THE ONL ACCOUNT THEY ALREADY HOLD, INSIDE THE BANK, ON SALARY DAY, IN A HOLDINGS CHECK, AT THE RM REVIEW AND AT DHANTERAS, WITH A SMALL MONTHLY ETF INSTALMENT THEY CHOOSE.

In our model: +2.3 pp by 31 Jan 2027 (14.7% to 17.0%) and 19,053 more active accounts for ₹16.5 lakh of cash. No advice, no offers, no paid media, no F&O prompts.

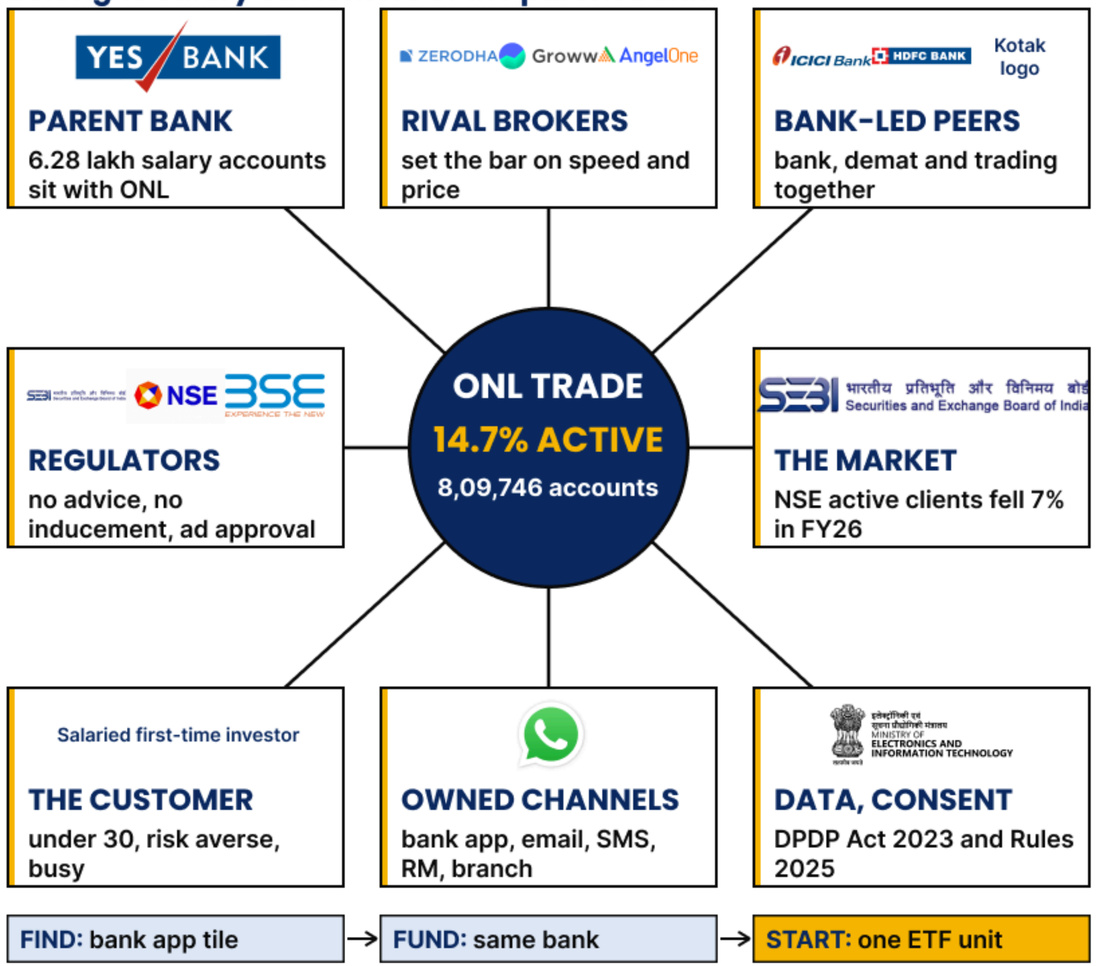
TEAM IDEAFORGE

Team Members	Institution	Role
Harsh Kawatra	Delhi Technological University	Team Leader
Gursimran Kaur	Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University	Member

harshkawatra11@gmail.com | Arthik Khayal 2026, ecotech, USME DTU

WHO DECIDES WHETHER AN ACCOUNT GETS USED

8,09,746 accounts, 1,19,339 active: 78% of the 6.9 lakh idle accounts belong to salary customers of the parent bank.



Logos identify organisations referred to in the analysis; no partnership or endorsement is implied.

Source: case Exhibits 1 and 2 | NSE active clients FY26 | team activation model fc66d11096 | logos identify organisations in the analysis; no partnership or endorsement is implied

ONL can add +2.3 pp of activation by 31 January 2027 by meeting salary customers inside the bank, for ₹16.5 lakh of cash and with no offers or F&O prompts

OUR ANSWER Show customers their forgotten ONL account where they already bank: on salary day, in a holdings check, at the RM review and at Dhanteras.

ONL AGAINST THE MARKET, %

Flat: a year of messages moved it 0.04 pp

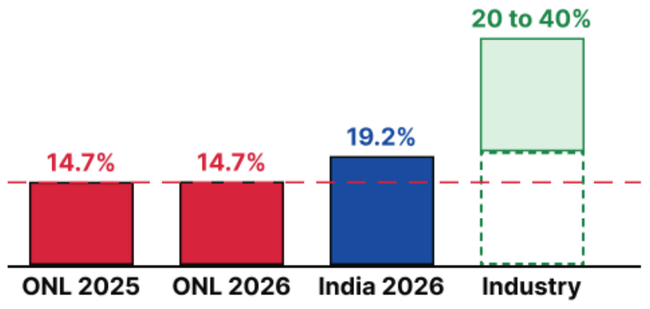
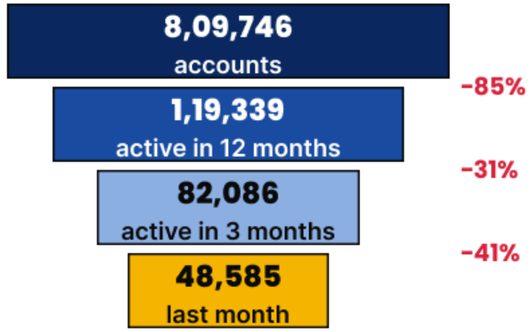
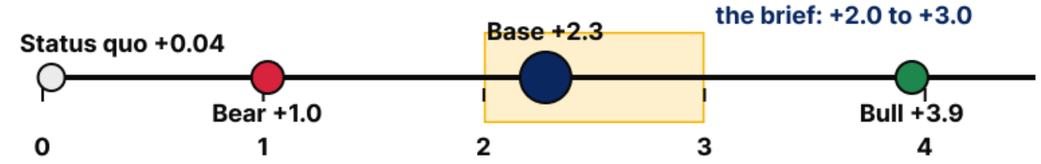


EXHIBIT 1 AS A FUNNEL

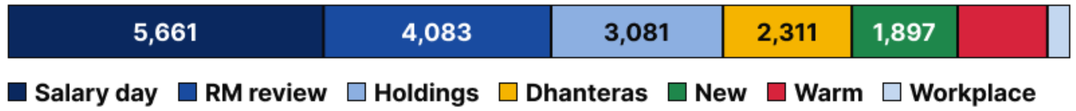


85 in 100 accounts: no trade in a year

THE TARGET, AND WHERE WE LAND, pp



Where the 19,053 extra actives come from, base case



	THE BRIEF ASKS	THE OBVIOUS MOVE	WHAT WE DO	THE PROOF	THE RESULT
1	**ACTIVATE** +200 to +300 bps in 3 months	~~More market messages~~ a year of them moved it 0.04 pp	**Meet it in the bank** salary day, holdings check, RM review, Dhanteras	Activation rate, % Today 14.7% · 31 Jan 2027 17.0%	**+2.3 pp** bear +1.0 pp, bull +3.9 pp
2	**SPEND LITTLE** lean budget, owned assets first	~~Buy users with paid media~~ ₹1,000 for each activated account	**Use rails the bank owns** app, statements, RM, WhatsApp, branch	Extra actives for ₹16.5 lakh Bank moments 19,053 · Paid media 1,649	**₹87** cash each; 11.6x paid media
3	**STAY COMPLIANT** SEBI, consent, no dark patterns	~~Offers, contests, F&O push~~ 88.5% of under-30 F&O traders lost money	**Facts only, consent first** no advice, no returns, no urgency	Checks passed, out of 5 Past messages 2 · Our messages 5	**0** offers, contests, F&O prompts

Source: case Exhibits 1 and 2 | NSE active clients and demat accounts, Sep 2026 | SEBI F&O study FY26 | team activation model fc66d11096 (T8, T10, T11, T14, T17)

78% of the 6.9 lakh idle accounts belong to salary customers, and a year of market-led messages left activation flat at 14.7%

THE BASE

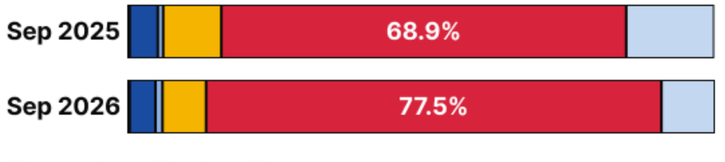
ACTIVE BY TRAILING WINDOW, SEP 2026, %

Segment	T12	T9	T6	T3	T1	YoY
Prestige	35	31	28	22	16	−3 pp
Elite	32	29	26	22	15	−4 pp
Elevate	37	34	31	27	13	−4 pp
Preferred	20	18	16	14	9	−1 pp
Salary Account	14	13	11	9	6	+1 pp
Credit Card	6	6	5	5	4	−3 pp

IDLE ACCOUNTS BY SEGMENT

Prestige	2,012
Elite	24,274
Elevate	5,967
Preferred	48,250
Salary Account	5,39,954
Credit Card	68,918

SHARE OF THE BASE BY SEGMENT, %



Salary accounts grew 24% in a year; credit card fell 34%

THE FUNNEL

THE FUNNEL, AND WHERE PAST EFFORT LANDED

Account opened	First login	Funded	First order	Habit
healthy volumes	account forgotten	separate funding step	fear of loss	no routine

Stages 2 and 3: nothing in ONL's plan aimed here

ONL's effort: market updates, research calls, offers, literacy

THE QUARTER IN ACCOUNTS

Item	Accounts
Active on 30 Sep 2026	1,19,339
Roll off next quarter	8,887 to 14,072
Active 31 Jan 2027, no change	1,23,067
Needed for +200 bps	16,701
Needed for +300 bps	25,051

So what: about 11,500 roll off a quarter

THE MARKET AROUND ONL

−7% NSE active clients FY26

19.2% active ratio, India

14.7% ONL, Sep 2026

87.7% F&O traders lost, FY26

WHY IT STALLS

FIVE WHYS ON ONE IDLE SALARY ACCOUNT

WHY 1 No order in a year: it came with the salary account

→ **WHY 2** It was never chosen, so it is not thought of as theirs

→ **WHY 3** ONL messages arrive as market news, easy to ignore

→ **WHY 4** In a falling market, 'stay invested' sounds like risk

→ **WHY 5** No ONL message reaches them in the bank app

Root cause: customers stall before they ever log in.

FIVE BIASES, AND THE DESIGN ANSWER

Bias	What it does here	Our design answer
Inattention	account is out of sight	show it in the bank app
Loss aversion	falling prices feel like losses	gold, liquid, index ETFs, small
Present bias	starting is always next month	act once, on salary day
Status quo	idle stays idle	an instalment they set and pause
Mental accounting	salary is spending money	a set-aside right after salary

Source: case Exhibits 1, 2a, 2b and funnel table | NSE active clients FY26 and Sep 2026 | demat accounts, Sep 2026 (24.06 crore) | SEBI F&O study FY26 | team model fc66d11096 (T2 to T8)

Meet the account inside four moments the bank already owns: salary day, a holdings check, the RM review and Dhanteras, with no advice and no offers

CONCLUSIVELY Selling the market harder tops out at 2.60 of 5; meeting the account inside the bank scores 4.40 and clears every guardrail.

THE CHOICE

EIGHT OPTIONS, ONE TEST, SCORED 1 TO 5

Option	Lift	Rules	Fall	Cost	Ships	Score
More market content	1	4	1	4	5	2.60
First-trade offers	3	2	2	2	5	2.60
Contests	3	1	2	3	3	2.30
Paid media	2	2	2	1	4	2.05
Referral rewards	2	3	2	3	4	2.60
F&O education push	2	1	2	4	4	2.25
Engine or app rebuild	1	4	3	1	1	2.15
Bank moments (ours)	4	5	4	5	4	4.40

Ours leads under all four weight sets tested (T18)

EXTRA ACTIVES BY SEGMENT AND MOMENT

Idle pool	Salary day	Holdings	RM review	Dhanteras	Workplace
Prestige 2,012		9	179	7	
Elite 24,274		108	1,623	81	
Elevate 5,967		27	399	20	
Preferred 48,250		215	1,882	161	
Salary 5,39,954	5,661	2,413		1,809	413
Card 68,918		309		232	
Total	5,661	3,081	4,083	2,311	413

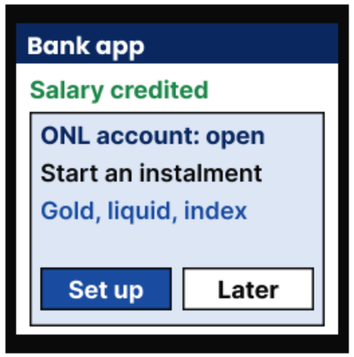
Plus 1,607 warm-cohort and 1,897 new-account first orders; each idle account is counted once.

FIVE CHECKS

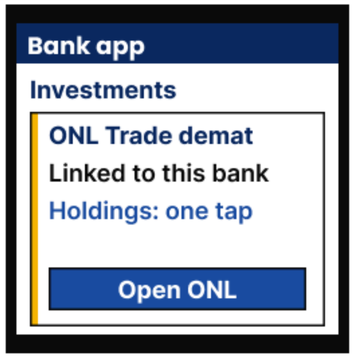
- **No advice** SEBI adviser rules
- **No return claims** SEBI, NSE ad code
- **No inducement** NSE circulars
- **Consent first** DPDP Rules 2025
- **No dark patterns** CCPA 2023, RBI 2026

THE BUILD

THE BANK APP, ON TWO DAYS

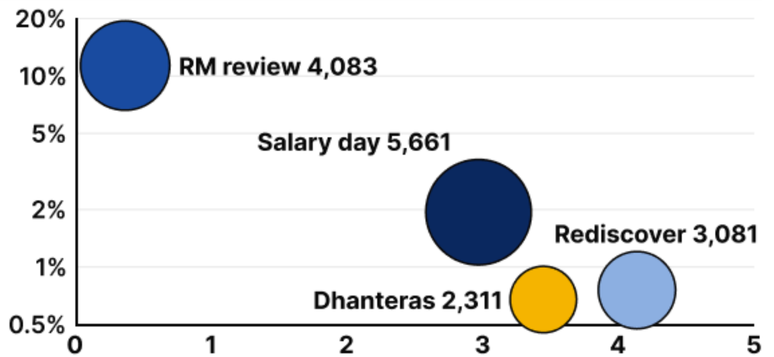


Salary day: the card



Any day: the tile

REACH AND CONVERSION, BUBBLE = ACTIVES



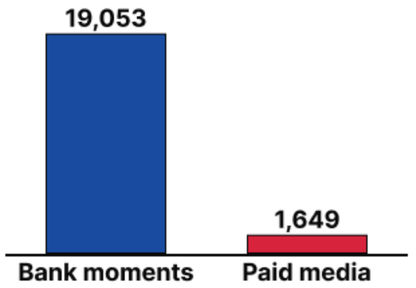
FIVE FUNNEL STEPS, FIVE FIXES

Opened	Guided first order, days 0 to 30	W4
Login	Bank-app tile, sign-on; video IPV if dormant	W4
Fund	UPI Autopay from the same bank	W5
First order	Monthly ETF instalment, customer's pick	W6
Habit	Daily holdings and net-worth view	W8

Source: SEBI finfluencer rules, Aug 2024 | NSE ad code, Feb 2023 | NSE inducement circulars | DPDP Rules 2025 | CCPA dark patterns 2023 | RBI conduct directions 2026 | team model fc66d11096 (T10, T17 to T19)

Base case adds 19,053 active accounts and +2.3 pp by 31 January 2027 for ₹16.5 lakh of cash, 11.6 times what the same money buys in paid media

SAME ₹16.5 LAKH OF CASH, TWO ROUTES



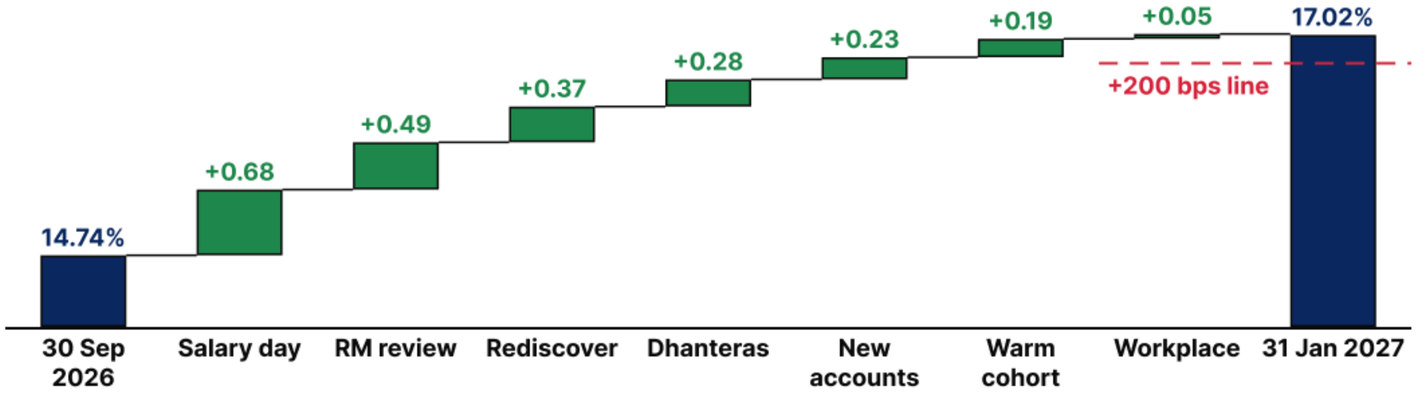
11.6x

the active accounts for the same money, base case

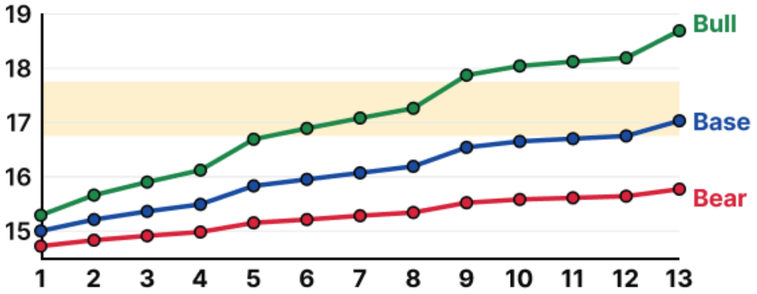
Bank moments: 19,053 at ₹87 each.
Paid media: 1,649 at ₹1,000.

₹87	₹285	₹62	17 months
cash each	all-in each	revenue a year	payback

FROM 14.7% TO 17.0%: WHERE THE POINTS COME FROM, pp



WEEK BY WEEK AGAINST THE TARGET BAND, %



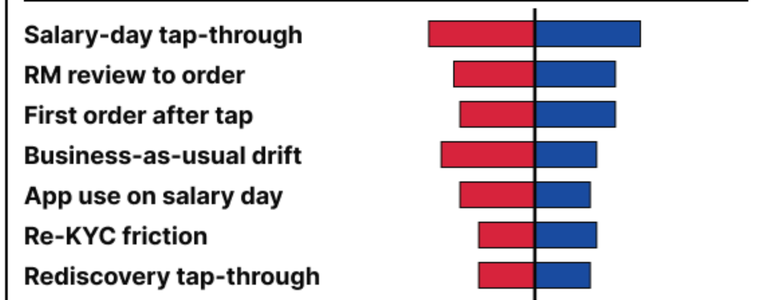
Shaded: +200 to +300 bps. Week 1 is Dhanteras and Diwali; weeks 5, 9 and 13 carry salary credits.

THREE SCENARIOS

Measure	Bear	Base	Bull
Extra actives	9,783	19,053	32,037
Rate, 31 Jan 2027	15.8%	17.0%	18.7%
Change from 14.7%	+1.0 pp	+2.3 pp	+3.9 pp
Highly active (T3)	11.3%	12.4%	14.0%
Cash per active	₹169	₹87	₹51
Salary-day tap	6%	8%	10%
Order after tap	26%	32%	38%
RM review to order	11%	15%	19%

Bear: the week-6 trigger adds RM capacity

WHAT MOVES THE BASE CASE, pp



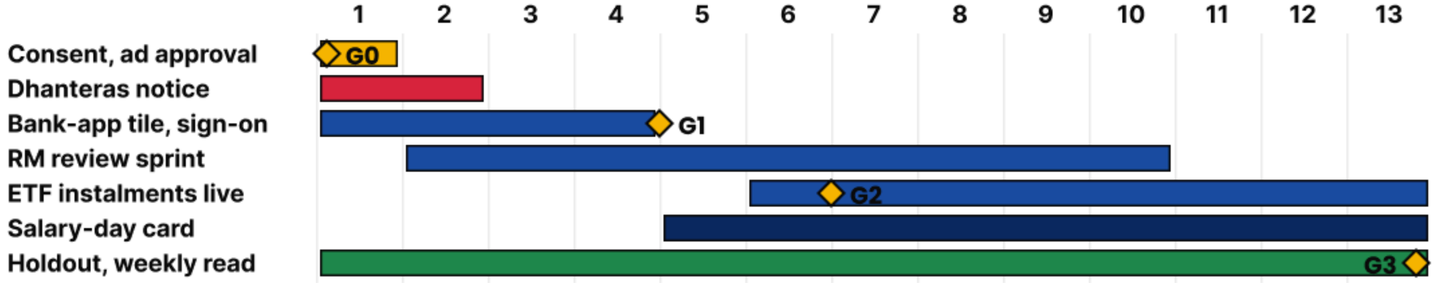
Every bar stays above +2.0 pp

Source: team activation model fc66d11096 (T10 to T16); assumptions A20 to A39 and A61 in the appendix | paid cost per activation is a team assumption checked against broker disclosures | case product table

Thirteen weeks, four gates and a 10% holdout: the lift is read every week and any moment that breaks a guardrail stops

THE PLAN

13 WEEKS FROM 2 NOVEMBER 2026, FOUR GATES



Salary credits land in weeks 5, 9 and 13; Dhanteras and Diwali fall in week 1 (6 and 8 November).

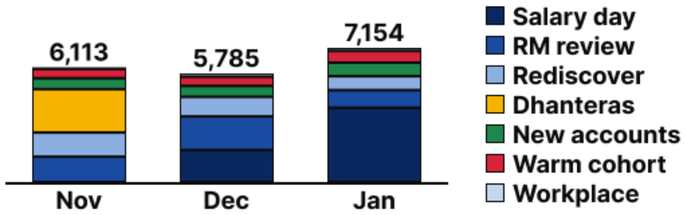
GO ONLY IF

Gate	When	Test
G0	Week 0	creatives cleared; consent text live
G1	Week 4	tile and sign-on live; holdout drawn
G2	Week 6	rate at or above 15.2%; else add RM reviews
G3	Week 13	lift read; scale or stop each moment

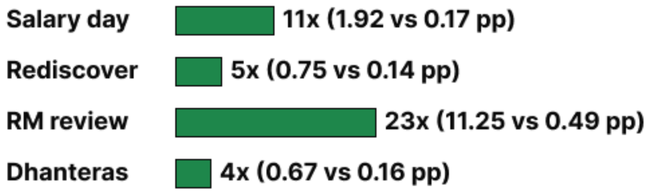
Not yet run: 30 customer interviews and 2 usability rounds in weeks 1 to 3 test the card and the tile.

THE PROOF

EXTRA ACTIVES ADDED EACH MONTH, BY MOMENT



HOLDOUT: LIFT VS DETECTABLE, pp



WHAT WE REPORT EVERY WEEK

KPI	Today	Week 6	Week 13
Activation rate	14.7%	15.9%	17.0%
Extra active accounts	0	9,917	19,053
Highly active (T3)	10.1%	tracked	12.4%
New actives in F&O	n/a	5% max	5% max
Opt-outs a send	n/a	0.5% max	0.5% max

THE RISKS

RISKS: PROBABILITY BY IMPACT

	Low	Med	High
High		4	
Med		3	1
Low			2, 5

1. Ad approval slips: file every creative in October
2. App slot not given: bank sponsor signs off first
3. Consent short: lead with servicing messages
4. Market falls further: gold, liquid, index ETFs only
5. Drift into F&O: no F&O prompts, knowledge check

GUARDRAILS: STOP LINES, CHECKED WEEKLY

Guardrail	Stop line	Action
New actives in F&O	above 5%	pause the moment
Opt-outs a send	above 0.5%	stop the message
Complaints per 10,000	above 1	compliance review
Messages a person a month	more than 4	hold further sends

Source: team plan and activation model fc66d11096 (T12, T19) | guardrail thresholds are team targets | SEBI F&O study FY26 | NSE advertisement code | research sections 26 to 29

Every number in the deck traces to the case exhibits, a stated assumption or a cited source, and the model passes 10 of 10 checks

A1 MODEL: HOW ONE EXTRA ACTIVE ACCOUNT IS COUNTED

Extra actives = sum over segments of idle x (1 − d + d x k) x [1 − (1 − p salary)(1 − p rediscover)(1 − p RM)(1 − p Dhanteras)] + workplace + warm x reach x re-trade + new x lift

Lever, base case	Reach	Tap or meet	First order	Chance per idle
Salary day	55%	8%	32%	1.41%
Rediscover	60%	4%	25%	0.60%
RM review, Elite	60%	meeting	15%	9.00%
Dhanteras	50%	3.0%	30%	0.45%

d = share idle 24 months or more (50%), k = order rate after re-KYC (0.50). Checks: 10 of 10 pass, hash fc66d11096. Rerun: python -X utf8 arthikkhayal-case/model/activation_model.py

A2 ASSUMPTIONS THAT MOVE THE ANSWER

ID	Assumption	Bear	Base	Bull	Checked in
A20	App use on salary day	45%	55%	62%	Lane F
A21	Salary-day tap-through	6.0%	8.0%	10%	Lane F
A22	First order after tap	26%	32%	38%	Lanes E, F
A24	Rediscovery tap-through	3.0%	4.0%	5.0%	Lane F
A27	RM review to first order	11%	15%	19%	Lanes B, E
A29	Dhanteras tap-through	2.2%	3.0%	4.0%	Lane G
A10	Idle 24 months or more	55%	50%	45%	Lanes C, D
A11	Order rate after re-KYC	0.42	0.50	0.58	Lane D
A61	Paid cost per activation	₹700	₹1,000	₹1,400	Lane F

A3 RULES WE DESIGN TO

Rule	Source	What it asks of us
No investment advice	SEBI (Investment Advisers) Regulations, 2013	neutral lists, no recommendations
Advertisement code	NSE code, February 2023	exchange approval first; a risk line on each
Finfluencers	SEBI amended regulations, August 2024	no tie-ups with unregistered persons
Inactive accounts	NSE circular, 25 October 2024	24 months idle; video IPV; no push to trade
Personal data	DPDP Act 2023; Rules notified November 2025	notice, consent, withdrawal, purpose limits
Dark patterns	CCPA Guidelines, November 2023	no false urgency, nagging or confirm-shaming

A4 SHORT FORMS AND SOURCES

Short	Meaning
AMC	annual maintenance charge
BSDA	Basic Services Demat Account
DPDP	Digital Personal Data Protection
ETF	exchange-traded fund
F&O	futures and options
IPV	in-person verification
KYC	know your customer
RM	relationship manager
SSO	single sign-on
T12, T3	trailing 12 and 3 months

Case: Arthik Khayal 2026 problem statement and Exhibits 1, 2a, 2b
SEBI: F&O trader study FY26; finfluencer rules, Aug 2024
NSE: inactive accounts, Oct 2024; advertisement code, Feb 2023
NSE active clients FY26 (IANS, Apr 2026)
Demat and active ratio, Aug 2026 (Business Today)
MeitY: DPDP Rules 2025
CCPA: dark pattern guidelines 2023
Thaler and Benartzi (2004), Save More Tomorrow
Karlan et al. (2016), reminders and saving
Full list: research Appendix A

Source: team activation model fc66d11096 | research document Appendix A (bibliography) and section 27 (assumptions register)

THANK YOU

TEAM IDEAFORGE

Team Members	Institution	Role
Harsh Kawatra	Delhi Technological University	Team Leader
Gursimran Kaur	Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University	Member

ecotech YES SECURITIES ANTHILL VENTURES kae capital

Research document, model and every source are in the appendix

harshkawatra11@gmail.com | Team IdeaForge | Arthik Khayal 2026, ecotech, USME DTU

RESEARCH DOCUMENT harshkawatra11.github.io/arthik-khayal/research.pdf →

Source: team activation model fc66d11096 | case Exhibits 1 and 2